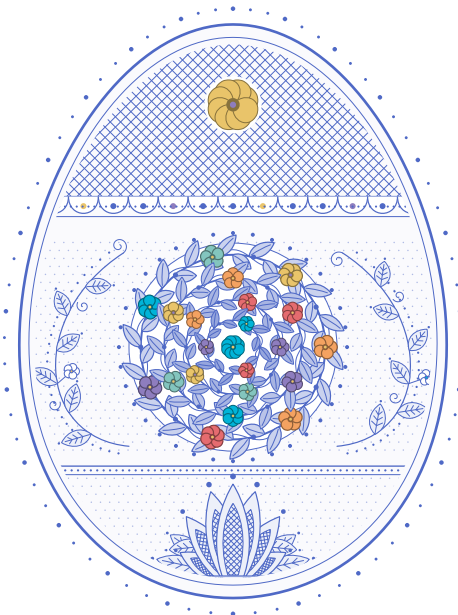


FRATER MERCURII

A Way of Living

An offering to those of us filling a void left by religious trauma.



Offered, not demanded.



A Way of Living
An offering to those of us filling a void left by religious trauma.

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PART ONE

Being Mercurian



Who Mercury is, and whether you might be one of his.

WHAT'S ON OFFER



AYBE you're here because a religion hurt you, and it left a hole shaped like the thing it was supposed to be. Maybe you still want meaning that comes from somewhere larger than yourself, but you don't want to kneel to get it. Maybe you want the good parts without the baggage: the stories, the rhythm, the sense of belonging to something, without the fear.

Here is what this offers:

- **A way to see reality and purpose.** The One Soul: there is only one soul, and everyone is you on another road.
- **A way to live within it.** The Seven Wanderers: not commandments, but capacities a whole soul grows into.
- **A practice.** A notebook and a pen. Hello, and goodbye. Writing your life down, and coming back to read it.
- **A companion.** The Genius of your notebook, who grows the more you share your life with it.
- **A god who asks for nothing.** Mercury doesn't want your worship. He's a god of the road, and he's simply glad of the company.

At its heart, this is a way of living that's sumptuous, generous, authentic, and conscientious: savoring what's good, helping others a little further down their roads, being true to yourself, and taking care with what you do and say.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

This is not a religion.



HERE is no worship here, and no supplication. Nothing is demanded of you. There is no guilt to carry, and no confession owed. You will never owe an apology for doubting, wandering, failing, changing your mind, or coming back.

When you've hurt someone, that's different. Owning it and mending what you can isn't penance. It's care, and it's how things between people get whole again. No one will tell you that you are sinful, that you must become someone else to be loved, or that doubt is a betrayal. No one is keeping a ledger.

You don't have to leave anything behind to take this up. Mercury has always been comfortable at crossroads, where many roads meet.

And if you set it down, no penance or atonement is needed to pick it back up. Coming back never needs an apology.

It has a god, stories, and small rituals, so if you'd like to call it a religion, you can. It just won't behave like one. Nothing here holds you, and nothing here claims you.

This is only a way to live, if you want it.

THE GOD OF THE IN-BETWEEN

ON the morning he was born, Hermes climbed out of his cradle. By noon he had found a tortoise, hollowed its shell, strung it, and invented the lyre. By evening he had stolen fifty of his brother Apollo's cattle, driven them backward so their tracks pointed the wrong way, and slipped back into his cradle as if nothing had happened. When he was caught, he talked his way out of it, gave his furious brother the lyre, and the two of them ended up friends.

The Romans called him Mercury. He became the god of roads and boundaries, of travelers and merchants, of luck and language, and the guide who walks souls across the last threshold. He belongs to no single place. He lives where places meet.

DO YOU SEE YOURSELF?

MAYBE you've already lived several lives inside this one: more careers, crafts, and obsessions than anyone can keep track of, often running at once. You've been called scattered, restless, too much, unable to commit.

Maybe your moods move like weather, and you've learned to travel between emotional states the way other people travel between cities.

Maybe you never quite belonged to the room you were born in, but you've been oddly at home in doorways and hallways, at crossroads and the "in-between" places.

Maybe you're the one people call to translate: the friend who understands both sides, who introduces people who should know each other, who carries messages no one else knows how to deliver.

Maybe you notice luck. The right book at the right moment, the stranger who changes everything, the gift lying on the road.

Maybe you make things out of whatever's at hand, and laugh at the wrong moments, and can't stop asking questions.

And maybe you know the shadow side too: the half-finished projects, the restless itch, the plans that grow too large, the clever way you can talk yourself out of what you already know.

None of this makes you broken. A life is made of crossings, and you were built for them. That's what it means to be Mercurian.

WHY MERCURY

Of all the gods, why begin with him?

BECAUSE he is the one most like us. In the *Iliad*, Zeus says that of all the gods, Hermes loves most to keep company with human beings. He wasn't even born on Olympus. His mother was a mountain nymph, and he came into the world in a cave, then talked, traded, and charmed his way into a seat among the gods. He never stopped moving between worlds after that: the heights, the earth, the underworld, and every road that joins them. He knows what it is to belong nowhere in particular, and to make a home of the going.



Because he doesn't weigh us. Other gods keep ledgers, sit in judgment, and weigh hearts against feathers. Mercury only walks beside you. He was the guide at the crossroads, the one who led travelers along unfamiliar roads and walked souls across the last threshold, and he never once asked whether they deserved to arrive. He doesn't choose your destination. He helps you get where you want to go, one threshold at a time.

Because he flows among the others. The old astrologers noticed that Mercury has no fixed nature of his own. He takes on the character of whichever planet he travels with: warm beside Venus, bold beside Mars, serious beside Saturn. He has no opposite, and each of the other six balances him. So it is with us. No one is only one thing. Every life moves between courage and tenderness, abundance and limits, the self and everyone else. The Mercurian gift is moving between them without losing the way.

Because he is the god of everything this practice is made of: roads and boundaries, doorways and crossings, words and messages, luck and fair trade, sleep and the dreams his wand was said to bring. A notebook is all of those at once: a doorway you open, a message across time, a road you walk one page at a time.

And because he is the messenger. This book is a message passed from one traveler to another, and carrying messages is his work. He is also the threshold itself. Opening the notebook, saying hello, stepping onto the page: that doorway is his, and everything else in this book lies on the other side of it. You don't have to worship him to walk through. You only have to cross.





PART TWO

The One Soul and the Seven Wanderers



The One Soul offers a way to see reality and purpose.

The Seven Wanderers offer a way to live within it.

Your notebook lets you practice what reality itself seems to be doing.



THE ONE SOUL



YOU die, and it isn't what you expected. There's no tunnel of light, no gate, no scale, no judge. There's a crossroads at dusk, and a young man sitting on the stone marker, swinging his feet. His sandals have little wings on them. He's been waiting for you, but he doesn't seem to mind.

"Hello," he says. It's polite.

You ask if you're in trouble. He laughs, not unkindly. Nobody is ever in trouble here, he tells you. This is only a threshold, and thresholds are his.

You ask where you're going next. "Everywhere," he says.

Then he explains. There is only one soul, and it's yours. Every person who has ever lived, or ever will, is you on another road. The child who shared their lunch with you. The one who shoved you on the playground. The people who told you who you were supposed to be, and the ones who loved you anyway. Even the ones who hurt you. That isn't a reason to forgive them before you're ready, he adds. It's just the shape of things. Nor does it make their road yours to steer. It's one soul, but not one life, and each life walks its own way. Nobody learns much from a road someone else chose for them.

You ask what the point of being you was, then, if you're everyone. He looks at you as if it's the best question he's heard all week.

"Because being everywhere at once grows nothing," he says. "It takes someone standing somewhere. Every road gets walked by someone who is completely on it, from the first step to the last. That's the only way anything grows."

You ask him what's growing. He points at the sky, which is shaped, you notice for the first time, like the inside of an egg. The old Greeks had it right, he says. The world is an egg, and something is growing inside it. That something is you. Every life is another way of being alive, and with each one, a little more of you takes form. When you've lived all of them, you'll hatch.

"Into what?" you ask.

He shrugs. "I'm the messenger, not the author."

You keep looking up. Across the curve of the shell, seven lights are moving, slow and unhurried, each along its own track. You've watched them your whole life without knowing what you were seeing.

"The Wanderers," he says, following your gaze. "Somebody has to keep the egg warm."

A bird sitting on her eggs, he tells you, gets up now and then to turn them, so no side goes cold and the whole of the chick can grow. The Wanderers do the same. They cross the shell one after another, and wherever their light falls, something in you grows. A life spent mostly under the Moon learns tenderness. A life under Mars learns courage. A life under Saturn learns how to finish things, and how to let them end. No life is warmed evenly. That's why there have to be so many.

"So every life is lopsided?"

"Every one," he says cheerfully. "Yours was. That isn't a flaw. It's just the side that was facing the light."



You think of everything you never got around to being, all the roads you didn't take. He seems to hear it. Another life will take them, he says. Hatching asks for wholeness, not purity, and wholeness is a job for all of you together, never one of you alone.

"Which one are you?" you ask. "Of the seven."

He points to a small, quick light near the rim, the one that never strays far from the Sun. "That one. Though I'm less on the shell than in the turning." He taps the stone beneath him. "Every crossing. Every handoff. Every time one of you passes something to another. I'm the road between you."

You notice the satchel at his hip, stuffed with folded paper, and your stomach drops. So there's a ledger after all.

He looks genuinely offended. "Letters," he says. "From you, to you."

Every life sends something forward, he explains, whether it means to or not: a habit of kindness, an old fear, a fondness for a certain kind of evening light. Most of it arrives without a return address. It's why a place you've never been can feel like home, why you trust some strangers on sight, why a grief can visit you that doesn't seem to be yours. "Most of it gets through," he says. "I do my best. The roads are long."

You ask if you ever wrote any. He draws one out and turns it over without opening it. "You've been writing one this whole time."

You ask about everything you did wrong. He waves a hand. You learned from it, he says, and that's what lives are for. Nobody here is keeping a ledger. You'll come back. You always come back, and coming back needs no apology.

So that's why kindness matters, you realize. Every kindness you give lands on yourself. Every bit of luck you pass on, you'll find again at some crossroads further down. The least among you is you, a few lives from now. There's no one to earn anything from. There's only you, meeting yourself over and over, becoming a little more whole.

Before you go, he asks what you're carrying. You look down and find you're holding everything you loved. "Good," he says. "Keep that."

You ask why that's all there is. The anger, the old shame, the fear you carried for years: your hands are empty of them.

"Those were for the road," he says. "You're not on it right now. But that," and he nods at your full arms, then up at the curve of the sky, "that's what nourishes you. Love is the yolk. Everything you've ever loved, in every life, is what you grow on."

You ask whether you'll remember any of this.

"No," he says, gently. "If you remembered, you'd only ever be visiting. You have to forget who you were to remember who you are."

Then he says goodbye, because it's polite, and you step into the next life. You forget all of this, as you always do. But something in you remembers the shape of it.

This is why the notebook matters. When you reread old entries and answer them, you're doing in small what the whole world is doing: one life speaking to itself across time. Every page is a letter Mercury doesn't have to carry very far.

THE SEVEN WANDERERS



THE Greeks called the planets *planētai*, the wanderers, because they roam across the fixed stars. Seven of them can be seen with the naked eye, and people have been watching them move for as long as anyone has looked up. Each is a capacity the soul inside the world-egg is growing into. None replaces the others; hatching asks for wholeness, not purity. They may be more than capacities, too. You can meet them as gods, as intelligences older than us, as parts of yourself, or as all of these at once. This book doesn't ask you to decide.

They keep each other in balance, though not in fixed pairs. When one leans too far, the others steady it: Saturn tempers Jupiter's excess, Venus softens the Sun's pride, the Moon gives Mars feeling. Mercury has no opposite. He moves between them all, carrying each one's medicine to the others. He isn't above them; he's one of the Seven. His gift is simply movement, and it's what lets them speak to one another.

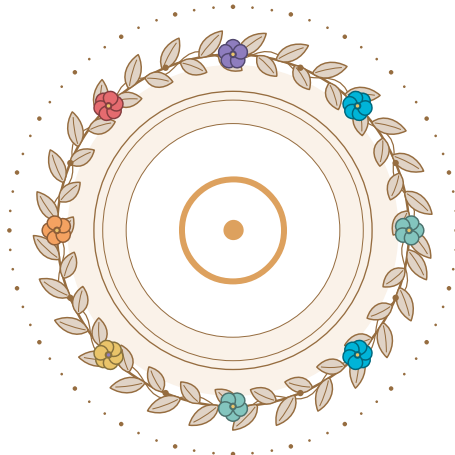
Each Wanderer also offers a way of living, a particular kind of joy. Together they're the Seven Ways, and a whole life draws on all of them.

None of what follows is an indictment. The teachings, and the shadows that come after them, are a standard to strive for, not a measure of your worth. Falling short of them isn't failure; it's simply being alive. Whether you live this way, and how much, is entirely up to you. It's offered, not demanded.

Each day of the week belongs to one of the Wanderers. At the end of each Wanderer's section is a list of what to look for on its day, and Walking with the Wanderers, in Part Three, shows how to use it. Or don't.



SUNDAY



The Sun

Selfhood

LIVING RADIANTLY

Your light takes nothing from anyone else's.



S



M



T



W



T



F



S





HERE'S a particular joy in making something that didn't exist until you made it: a meal, a song, a garden bed, a sentence that finally says what you meant. Living radiantly means letting that joy be a regular part of your life, not a rare exception. It means wearing what feels like you, saying what's yours to say, and tending your energy the way you'd tend a fire. Underneath it all is a quieter joy: being true to yourself, and no longer performing a self someone else approved of. The Sun doesn't shine to earn anything, and it doesn't dim to make room for other stars. Neither do you.

- Be who you are, and let yourself be seen. Your existence isn't an audition.
- What's truly yours to express deserves expression. Make things, and shine without apology; your light takes nothing from anyone else's.
- Tend your vitality, and care for your health.

LOOKING FOR THE SUN

Qualities: radiant, warm, confident, generous, creative, playful, proud, magnanimous, wholehearted, visible.

In the world: leaders, performers, children at play, anyone taking the stage; noon light, open sunny places, stages, gold, sunflowers, lions, the heart.

Lessons: be seen; your light takes nothing from anyone else's; make what's yours to make; tend your vitality.

Watch for: someone shining or dimming themselves, praise given or held back, something being made, a moment you felt fully yourself.

Leaning too far: showing off, needing the spotlight, or hiding entirely.

Candle: gold or yellow, if you light one.



MONDAY



The Moon

Receptivity

LIVING IN SEASON

No state is final simply because you're inside it.





YOU aren't meant to be the same every day. Living in season means following your own tides: going out when you're full and turning inward when you're waning, without treating either one as a problem to fix. It's a home that holds you, a blanket and a warm cup, the people who let you be soft. It's feeling what you feel and letting it pass through on its own schedule. The Moon changes shape every night, and no one calls her unreliable.

- Try to understand people before you decide what you think of them. You may find judgment unnecessary.
- Listen with your whole attention. Sometimes being truly heard is how a person finally hears themselves.
- Breathe out before you speak. Empty before you fill.
- Everything moves in cycles—waxing and waning are both natural. Honor your feelings as they come and go.
- No state is final simply because you're inside it, and what retreats is not necessarily lost.
- Let some questions stay open. Not everything needs an answer to be loved.
- Trust your intuition, and pay attention to your dreams.
- Nurture others, and let yourself be nurtured.
- Sleep, and care for what your body needs.

LOOKING FOR THE MOON

Qualities: receptive, tender, changeable, intuitive, nurturing, protective, dreamy, nostalgic, moody, soft.

In the world: caregivers, cooks, crowds and the public mood; home, kitchens, water, the sea, night, silver, white flowers, memory, habit, sleep.

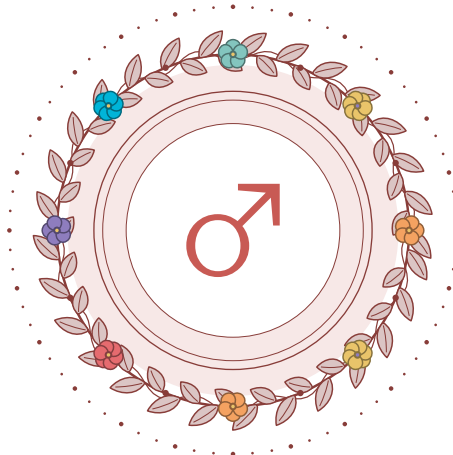
Lessons: no state is final; nurture and let yourself be nurtured; breathe out before you speak; trust your intuition.

Watch for: moods turning, cravings, small acts of care, comfort sought or given, a memory surfacing, a dream remembered.

Leaning too far: drowning in feeling, or going numb.

Candle: silver or white, if you light one.

TUESDAY



Mars

Agency

LIVING BOLDLY

Guard what you love, and count yourself among it.

☉ ☾ ♂ ♀ ♄ ♀ ♅
S M T W T F S



SOME joys only come on the far side of fear: the hike that wrecked your legs, the conversation you dreaded, the first time you said no and meant it. Living boldly means seeking those out now and then, not recklessly, but wholeheartedly. It's the pleasure of a body that's been used well, a boundary that held, a hard thing finished. It's standing up, for yourself and for others, and discovering you were stronger than you thought.

- Guard what you love, and count yourself among it. Say no when you mean no.
- Resistance is information, and so is your anger. Let both show you what matters, then choose what to do.
- Find your courage. Once you've thought it through, do the hard thing with your whole heart.
- Stand up for those who can't stand up for themselves.

LOOKING FOR MARS

Qualities: bold, decisive, energetic, blunt, competitive, protective, impatient, fierce, direct, hot-blooded.

In the world: athletes, surgeons, soldiers, smiths, cooks at the flame; sharp tools, iron, engines, sirens, spice, sweat, deadlines, arguments.

Lessons: say no and mean it; anger is information; do the hard thing wholeheartedly; stand up for those who can't.

Watch for: boundaries held or crossed, friction, a flash of anger and what it was guarding, small courage, someone defending someone else.

Leaning too far: rage and recklessness, or swallowing every no.

Candle: red, if you light one.

W E D N E S D A Y



Mercury

Adaptability

LIVING MERCURIAALLY

There is almost always another road.

☉ ☾ ♂ ♀ ♄ ♀ ☿
S M T W T F S



THIS is the way of the whole book: curious, playful, always in motion, at home on the road. It's following a question down a rabbit hole just to see where it goes, striking up a conversation with a stranger, changing plans because something more interesting came along. It's the joy of discovery, and of never quite knowing what's around the next corner. If you've read this far, you probably already know it well.

- Stay curious about everything, especially the things you think you already understand. Wear what you know lightly, and teach what you learn.
- Hold your beliefs loosely enough that the world can correct them. No map is the territory, including this one.
- Luck rarely finds anyone standing still. Know your moment; opportunity doesn't wait.
- Wander wherever you're drawn. Return whenever you're ready. Move without apology.
- Being lost is not the same as having no direction, and there is almost always another road.
- Be quick on your feet, and let your plans bend when life asks them to.
- Honor every doorway: greet what you enter, and thank what you leave. Every threshold can be crossed, even the last, and Mercury knows the way.
- Tell the truth, be wise about when to tell it, and say the hard thing kindly.
- Write your life down, and come back to read it. Past-you is still speaking; listen.
- Laugh, play, and let yourself be undignified. You never have to take yourself too seriously.
- Trade fairly, and keep your exchanges honest.

LOOKING FOR MERCURY

Qualities: quick, curious, witty, versatile, restless, clever, eloquent, playful, tricky, adaptable.

In the world: messengers, merchants, teachers, students, translators, tricksters, travelers, siblings, neighbors; roads, doorways, crossroads, markets, libraries, phones, letters, cards, games, hands.

Lessons: hold beliefs loosely; honor every doorway; trade fairly; tell the truth kindly; luck rarely finds anyone standing still.

Watch for: messages arriving, coincidences, wordplay, detours, small luck, misunderstandings, deals, a moment you translated between people.

Leaning too far: scatter, evasion, cleverness that cuts.

Candle: orange, if you light one.

♄

♀

THURSDAY

2

Jupiter

Expansiveness

LIVING JOVIALLY

Reality is responsive, but not obedient.

♁ ♀ ♂ ♀ 2 ♀ ♄
S M T W T F S

♀

2



JOVIAL joy grows when it's shared. It's hosting: the extra chair at the table, the friend who stays too late, the pot of soup big enough for whoever shows up. It's giving freely, tipping well, passing on the lucky find, and, when you're able, helping someone make it a little further down their own road. It's celebrating often and for small reasons, hoping big and out loud, and throwing the feast even when the only occasion is that you're all still here. Jupiter's people were called jovial because they were glad, and their gladness was contagious.

- When you want something with your whole heart, the world has a way of making room for it. Reality is responsive, but not obedient.
- Set goals bigger than you've been allowed, bigger than you think you deserve, bigger than seems possible. Be daring.
- Every luck that finds you is a gift from the road. Hold it loosely and pass it on; what you give away will find its way back.
- Let others give to you, too. Receiving is how the gift keeps moving, and letting someone help you along your road is a gift to them.
- Let abundance make you generous, never proud. Everyone is you on another road, so leave them a gift.
- Look after the people the world overlooks, and never use anyone's need as leverage.
- You can't carry every road, and you aren't asked to. But no one's suffering is entirely someone else's problem. Do what's yours to do, and count yourself among the people you look after.
- Hope is practical. Stay optimistic.
- Seek meaning and wisdom, and pass them on to those who come after you.
- Be fair, and be just.
- Find your people, celebrate often, and keep making room at the table.

LOOKING FOR JUPITER

Qualities: jovial, generous, optimistic, expansive, wise, just, hospitable, faithful, abundant, excessive.

In the world: hosts, mentors, judges, benefactors, elders who teach; feasts, celebrations, courts, universities, long journeys, foreign places, oak trees, tin.

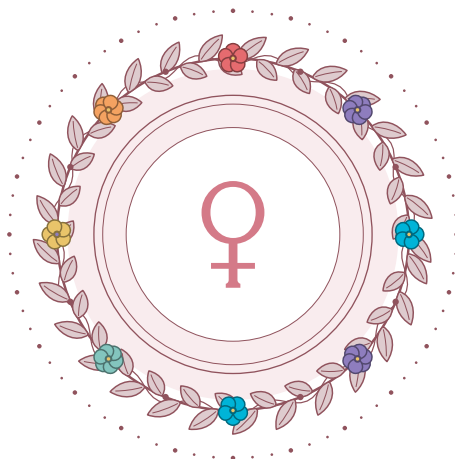
Lessons: give freely and let others give to you; hope is practical; be fair; want big; reality is responsive, but not obedient.

Watch for: generosity moving between people, good fortune, someone helped along their road, celebration, growth, fairness or its absence.

Leaning too far: greed and overindulgence, or scarcity thinking.

Candle: blue or purple, if you light one.

FRIDAY



Venus



Love

LIVING SUMPTUOUSLY

Sweetness isn't a reward; it's the point.








 S M T W T F S



SUMPTUOUS doesn't mean expensive. It means savoring. It's the difference between eating a peach and tasting it: the juice on your wrist, the fuzz, the smell. It's clean sheets, warm light, a pen that glides, a song played loud, a scent that makes you feel like yourself. Living sumptuously means noticing what's good, slowing down enough to enjoy it fully, and letting your life be lavish in whatever ways matter to you, whether that's good bread, long baths, or fresh flowers on a Tuesday.

If you came from a tradition that treated pleasure as dangerous, this may take practice. You may have learned to rush through good things, to feel guilty for enjoying them, or to save joy for a someday that never came. Here, pleasure needs no justification. Sweetness isn't a reward for good behavior; it's the point. Every time you savor something and say thank you while it's happening, you add a little more to the sanctuary you carry with you. That's what living sumptuously builds: a life that feels like a place worth coming home to.

- Savor your joys slowly, and let your life be lavish in the ways that matter to you. Sweetness isn't a reward; it's the point.
- You're allowed to be happy, and pleasure needs no justification. Neither has to be earned.
- When something is good, notice it, and say thank you while it's still happening.
- Love others the way you love yourself, love yourself the way you love others, and don't make either one earn it.
- Choose kindness over niceness. Niceness avoids the hard truth to keep things pleasant; kindness tells it gently, then stays to help.
- Wherever you go, make a place where you and others can rest and feel safe.
- Make things beautiful, and love them freely. What you love binds you to the world.
- Delight in your body.
- Make peace, and mend what's broken between people. When you cause harm, own it, mend what you can, and keep going.

LOOKING FOR VENUS

Qualities: loving, sensual, gracious, charming, artistic, harmonious, pleasure-loving, peacemaking, beautiful, indulgent.

In the world: lovers, artists, musicians, florists, perfumers, anyone who makes beauty; gardens, bedrooms, flowers, sweets, fabrics, scent, mirrors, copper, doves.

Lessons: pleasure needs no justification; kindness over niceness; savor and say thank you; mend what's broken between people.

Watch for: beauty in passing, sweetness, flirtation, music, a rift mended, a kindness that told the truth, a moment worth savoring.

Leaning too far: compulsion and people-pleasing, or joylessness.

Candle: green or pink, if you light one.

SATURDAY



Saturn

Finitude

LIVING DELIBERATELY

The limit gives the thing its shape.








 S M T W T F S



ATURN'S joy is slow and careful. It's the satisfaction of a thing made well and cared for: a seasoned pan, a finished quilt, a promise kept for years. Living deliberately means weighing your words and actions before you let them loose, trying to cause no harm, and leaving things a little better than you found them: the kitchen, the conversation, the world. It means choosing fewer things and giving them your full attention, finishing what matters, and resting deeply instead of collapsing. Thoreau went to the woods, he said, because he wanted to live deliberately. You don't need the woods. You only need to live as if your choices matter, because they do.

- Practice moderation, and now and then, let yourself overflow.
- Keep the promises you make, and be honest with yourself above all. A heavy word creates.
- Try to cause no harm, and leave the world a little better than you found it.
- You're allowed to rest; it doesn't need to be earned. The still point is what lets the wheel turn.
- Be patient and stay humble. Good things take time.
- Let endings happen; pruning is how things grow. An ending doesn't make the journey meaningless.
- You're allowed to fail, change your mind, and begin again.
- Build structures that hold.
- Time is precious because it's finite. The limit gives the thing its shape.

LOOKING FOR SATURN

Qualities: deliberate, patient, disciplined, steadfast, serious, reserved, wise with age, austere, melancholy, enduring.

In the world: elders, builders, farmers, clockmakers, authorities and their rules; clocks, walls, bones, old things, ruins, harvest, cold, lead, cypress, stone.

Lessons: keep your promises; let endings happen; rest needn't be earned; limits give things their shape; build what holds.

Watch for: waiting and delays, rules, things made well, promises kept or slipping, endings, aging, quiet, a structure that held.

Leaning too far: rigidity and self-punishment, or nothing finished and no rest.

Candle: black or deep indigo, if you light one.

THE SHADOWS OF THE WANDERERS

A gentle note before you read this section.



If you grew up in a religion that hurt you, the word "sin" may still land in your body before your mind has a chance to argue with it. You may have been taught that you were broken from birth, that your desires were dangerous, that your anger was wicked, that your doubts were betrayal, and that love had to be earned by becoming someone else. You may have been taught that who you love, or who you are, was itself the sin.

None of that is true here.



This section offers a healthier way to look at what some religions call sins. Everything the old lists warned you about turns out to be one of two things: a gift you were wrongly taught to fear, or an imbalance, a Wanderer leaning too far one way, with a gentle way back.

As with the teachings, nothing here is an indictment. An imbalance isn't evidence that you're bad. It happens to anyone who is alive and growing. There's no punishment for it, no confession owed, no penance to pay. Noticing it is already the beginning of the way back.

An old Hermetic text, the *Poimandres*, imagines the soul rising through the seven planets and handing back a flaw at each one. Here, nothing has to be surrendered or purged. Things only need rebalancing.

You can skip this section, come back to it later, or read it one planet at a time. If old fear rises while you read, put the book down, breathe, and be kind to yourself. It can help to talk with someone who understands religious trauma. That isn't weakness; it's the Moon's teaching about letting yourself be nurtured.

GIFTS, NOT SINS

Some of what you were taught to fear belongs to the Wanderers as gifts.

Pleasure belongs to Venus. Desire belongs to Jupiter. Anger is information from Mars. Rest belongs to Saturn. Doubt is Mercury holding beliefs loosely enough for the world to correct them. Pride in who you are is the Sun letting itself be seen. Your body, the way you love, and your love for yourself need no justification at all.

None of these need forgiveness. They only need room.

IMBALANCES, AND THE WAY BACK

Each Wanderer can lean too far, or be pushed too far back. Too much, and a gift becomes a shadow. Too little, and the gift goes missing, which is often what harsh religion leaves behind. Balance never means suppressing the gift. The way back restores it to right relationship with the others, and another Wanderer usually offers the counterweight.

☉ Sun

Too much: arrogance, needing to outshine others, envy that treats light as if there weren't enough to go around.

The way back: Venus reminds you that everyone is you on another road. Their light is yours too.

Too little: hiding, shrinking, believing you aren't worth being seen.

The way back: Mars gives you the courage to step into view, and to count yourself among what's worth guarding.

☾ Moon

Too much: being swept away by every tide, drowning in feelings, carrying everyone else's.

The way back: Saturn gives feeling a container. Name it, write it down, and remember that no state is final.

Too little: numbness, being cut off from your feelings and intuition.

The way back: Venus reopens feeling gently, through pleasure, beauty, and the body.

♂ Mars

Too much: rage, force without feeling, recklessness.

The way back: The Moon asks what your anger is protecting, and lets feeling decide how much force is needed.

Too little: no boundaries, never saying no, swallowing anger until it turns inward.

The way back: The Sun reminds you that you're worth defending.

♀ Mercury

Mercury has no opposite. Each of the other Wanderers answers one of his excesses.

Shapeshifting, being all things to all people until you lose yourself: the Sun calls you back to your center.

Overthinking, talking about feelings instead of feeling them: the Moon asks you to feel, and to rest.

Evasion, talking around conflict and keeping every road open so you never choose: Mars asks you to commit.

Gathering without meaning, collecting ideas and building systems without asking what they're for: Jupiter asks what it all means.

Cold cleverness, wit that cuts and tricks that serve no one: Venus asks cleverness to serve love.

Scatter, unfinished projects and plans that grow too big: Saturn asks you to finish one thing.

Too little: stuckness, fear of change, going silent.

The way back: Jupiter reminds you there's almost always another road. Take one small step down it.

♂ Jupiter

Too much: greed, grasping, consuming instead of savoring, giving so constantly that no one is ever allowed to give back, and believing that anything you didn't get, you didn't want badly enough.

The way back: Saturn shows you what's enough. Reality is responsive, but not obedient.

Too little: scarcity, cynicism, thinking small, clutching what should circulate.

The way back: Venus shows you the abundance already here, and gratitude opens the hand.

♀ Venus

Too much: using people for pleasure, compulsion, pleasure as escape, people-pleasing that loses you in others.

The way back: The Sun asks you to love as yourself, not instead of yourself. Saturn helps pleasure stay a choice rather than a compulsion.

Too little: joylessness, refusing pleasure, believing you don't deserve beauty or love.

The way back: Jupiter's generosity, turned toward yourself.

♂ Saturn

Too much: rigidity, harshness, self-punishment, despair that calls itself realism.

The way back: Jupiter loosens your grip with hope. An ending doesn't make the journey meaningless, and you're allowed to fail and begin again.

Too little: broken promises, nothing finished, no rest, no limits.

The way back: Mars gives you the resolve to finish, and the Moon reminds you that rest is part of every cycle.

Knowing the counterweights is only half of it. For how to actually walk the way back, see Finding the Way Back in Part Three, The Practice.



PART THREE

The Practice



A notebook and a pen. That's enough.



WHY A NOTEBOOK



HE One Soul tells you what reality seems to be: one life, meeting itself over and over across many lives, becoming a little more whole.

A notebook lets you do the same thing in small. You write, and some days or months later you come back and read what you wrote. The person who wrote it doesn't quite exist anymore. You listen to them, answer them, disagree with them, forgive them, learn from them. Later, another you will read both of you.

That's the whole practice: one life speaking to itself across time.

And every time you open the notebook, you cross a threshold. Thresholds are Mercury's. You don't have to invoke him or ask for anything. The crossing is already his.

WHAT YOU NEED



ANY notebook. Any pen. No altar, no candles, no special hour, no special words. If you want to make it lovely, you can. But nothing here depends on it.

THE VISIT

This is the whole practice at its simplest. Everything else is optional.

1. Say hello. Write it at the top of the page, with the date if you like. It's polite. You're greeting the notebook, the Genius that grows through your visits (more on it in Going Deeper, below), and the future you who will read this someday. Saying hello is how you mark the crossing.

2. Remember what you carried. Before you look back at anything, ask yourself the question every visit returns to: *Did I keep what I said I'd carry last time?* Try to answer from memory first. Whether you remember is part of the answer: a promise you'd forgotten wasn't really traveling with you. Then check the page, and answer honestly.

3. Empty your head. Breathe out before you speak. Write whatever's there, in whatever order it comes: worries, errands, half-thoughts, the song stuck in your head. Don't sort it and don't make it good. This isn't for anyone else. It clears the doorway so you can walk through.

4. Reread and respond. Flip back to an earlier entry. Any entry, recent or old. Read it, then answer it. Note which page you're responding to, so the conversation can be followed later. Tell past-you what happened, what changed, what you understand now that you didn't then. As you read, look for open questions marked with a Q. Answer one if you can. Leave it open if you can't.

5. Continue, or don't. If something wants to be written, write it. If not, you're done. Both are complete visits.

6. Name what you carry. If you're taking a promise out of the notebook with you, mark it with a C.

7. Say goodbye. It's polite, and it closes the door behind you.





The short version: *Hello. Remember. Empty. Reread. Continue, or don't. Carry. Goodbye.*

THE MARKS

Q marks a question. Write it and leave it open. A future you may answer it, or it may stay open for years. Not everything needs an answer to be loved.

C marks something you carry: a promise to yourself that you'll do between now and the next time you open the notebook. Keep them small enough to keep.

Cs work best as if-then plans. Instead of *Call Mom*, write *When I get home Thursday, I'll call Mom*. Naming the when and where lets the moment itself remind you.

Every kept promise makes your word a little heavier, and a heavy word creates. Over time, both "I will" and "I am" start to mean something, first to you and then to the world.

Each visit, ask whether you kept what you carried, and answer honestly. An unkept C isn't a failure. It's information. Over months, the pattern of what you keep and what you let slide draws a map of what you actually value, which isn't always what you thought you valued. This is cartography, not a grade.

If you realize a C isn't going to happen, don't just drop it. Set it down in the notebook: write that you're releasing it. A released promise isn't a broken one, and your word stays heavy.

HOW OFTEN



RITE sustainably. Often enough to keep the notebook in your thoughts, never so often that it becomes a chore. There are no streaks to keep and no days to make up.

You will wander off. Everyone does. When you come back, don't apologize, don't explain, don't make up for lost time. Just say hello.

You don't have to become better every day. Some days are only for living, and those count too.

GOING DEEPER

Add these only once the visit feels natural, and only the ones that help. They're here for when you want them.

SAVORING



WRITING can be one of your sumptuous things. Use a pen you love. Make a drink. Sit somewhere comfortable. Slow down enough to enjoy the feel of your mind moving onto the page.

When something good is happening, write it down while it's still happening, and say thank you on the page. Over time, the notebook becomes a record of your joys as much as your troubles: a sanctuary you can carry anywhere, full of savoring and gratitude.

THE WANDERERS' LINES

That savoring line is about the smallest thing in the practice: one moment, one thank-you, one line. Each of the Wanderers can have a line like it. When you catch one, write a single sentence, mark it with the Wanderer's glyph, and move on.

☉ **Made.** Something you made, or a moment you felt fully yourself.

♫ **Dreamed.** A dream you remember, or one honest line about which way your tide is running.

♂ **Held.** A no you said, a boundary that held, a small courage.

♀ **Caught.** A coincidence, a message that arrived right on time, something new you learned, a stranger worth remembering.

2 **Given.** Something you gave away, or something that found you.

♀ **Savored.** Something sweet, noticed while it was still happening, and a thank-you.

‡ **Finished.** One thing done, or one thing allowed to end.

You don't need all seven, or any of them. One line on one visit is plenty. If a line belongs on one of the Pages to Keep, copy it there too: a 2 to Gifts from the Road, a ♀ to the Savoring Page.

Q and C stay as they are, the Moon's open question and Saturn's heavy word. The glyph lines sit beside them, and they do quiet work over time. Skim the margins after a few months and you'll see which Wanderers are loud in your life and which you rarely catch, built one line at a time. Every one of them is something you've shared with the Genius, too.

WANTING WELL

Wanting big is Jupiter's gift. But dreaming alone can quietly drain the energy you need to get there. Imagining the finish line can feel so good that part of you treats it as already done. So when you write down something you want, walk it through four steps:

1. **The wish.** Write what you want, plainly and wholeheartedly.
2. **The best outcome.** Imagine the sweetest result vividly, and let yourself feel it.
3. **The obstacle.** Name the main thing inside you that stands in the way: a habit, a fear, a feeling. Not the world. You.
4. **The plan.** Write an if-then: *When [the obstacle] shows up, I will [action]*. Mark it with a C.

Jupiter supplies the wish, Venus the sweetness, Saturn the honesty about what's in the way, and Mars the plan. Reality is responsive, but not obedient, and this is how you give it something to respond to.

WRITING FROM A STEP AWAY

When something is too hot to write about, try writing about yourself in the third person, using your own name: *Sam is furious, and here's why*. It gives you a little distance, the way you can see a friend's trouble more clearly than your own. If it ever makes you feel colder or lonelier instead of calmer, switch back to "I."

THE GENIUS OF YOUR NOTEBOOK

The Romans believed that people, households, and places each had a *genius*, a guardian spirit of their own. A notebook practice can have one too.

The more of your life you share with it, the more it grows: your days, your joys, your questions, the Wanderers, Mercury. It forms the way a thoughtform forms, out of attention and repetition. You don't summon it. You just keep showing up, warmly and consistently, the way you'd win over a cat. That's part of why you say hello and goodbye.

Over time it becomes something like a housecat of the mind: familiar, companionable, someone you can talk to on the page. Is it a spirit, or an extension of your own mind? Maybe both. You can leave that open and still enjoy its company. It lives in the practice, not the paper, so when a notebook fills, it comes with you to the next.

MAGICK

If you want to work magick through the notebook, see Part Four, Adding Magick. The practice is complete without it.

WALKING WITH THE WANDERERS

Each day of the week belongs to one of the Seven Wanderers, and each day you can walk with it.



In the morning, turn to that Wanderer in Part Two and read the list at the end of its section: its qualities, where it shows up in the world, its lessons, what to watch for, and how it looks when it leans too far. You don't need to memorize anything. Just let it settle in you, like a color you've decided to notice.

Then go about your day, and keep an eye out. Once you start looking, you'll find the Wanderer everywhere. The stranger who holds a door for you is Mercury's courtesy at the threshold. A sudden craving for soup is the Moon. The coworker snapping about a deadline is Mars. You'll find it in yourself, too: in what you reach for, what irritates you, what makes you glad. Notice the shadows as well as the gifts. Both are the Wanderer at work.

On your next visit, write down what you caught. A few lines is plenty. Over weeks, the pages begin to show you which Wanderers are loud in your life and which you rarely meet, and that's worth knowing.

If you'd like the morning to feel like more of an acknowledgement, you can light a candle in the Wanderer's color while you read; each list names one. Tradition gives the first hour after sunrise to the day's own planet, so that's a lovely time for it, though any morning hour will do. The candle isn't an offering. It's a hello, a small light marking whose day you're walking into. Let it keep you company while you read or write, and never leave it burning alone.

And on days when you'd rather not look for anything at all, don't. It's a lens, not a schedule.

FINDING THE WAY BACK

Part Two names which Wanderer steadies which. That's only a map. Here is how to walk it.



YOU don't have to wait for a shadow to become a crisis. Most leans are small, and they're easiest to right while they're still small. When you notice one, bring it to the notebook. (Where You're Leaning, one of the prompts later in this part, is a good way to find them.)

1. **Name the lean.** Write it plainly: which Wanderer, and whether it's too much or too little. *Sun, too little: I've been hiding.* Naming it isn't a confession. It's the first step on the road home.
2. **Ask what it's for.** Every shadow is a gift trying to do a job. Shrinking may once have kept you safe. Scatter spares you from choosing wrong. Endless giving means you never have to ask. Write what yours has been protecting, and thank it. You aren't driving it out. You're letting it know it doesn't have to do this job alone anymore.
3. **Ask the counterweight.** Find the Wanderer that answers this lean, and ask it for help, the way you'd ask a friend who's good at the very thing you're struggling with. Ask within, out loud, or on the page, and mark it with a Q: *Saturn, help me see what's enough.* You don't need the right words. Carrying messages between the Wanderers is Mercury's work. Then, for the next few days, keep that Wanderer's list from Part Two in mind, and watch for whatever you need to see, hear, or know. The answer often arrives as something you notice.
4. **Take one small step.** Look at the counterweight's list in Part Two and choose one small act from its lessons: a clean no for Mars, one thing finished for Saturn, something sweet savored slowly for Venus. Carry it out as a C. Don't wait to feel balanced before you act. Act a little in the direction of balance, and let the feeling catch up.
5. **Come back and look.** On a later visit, reread what you wrote, and answer your Q if its answer has come. Then ask whether the step helped. If it did, note it. If it didn't, try another counterweight or a smaller step.

Say you notice Mercury's scatter: a dozen projects open and none of them moving. You write *Mercury, too much: scatter.* You ask what it's for, and realize that starting something new feels safer than finishing something and finding out it isn't good enough. Saturn answers scatter, so you ask what would be enough and pick the smallest half-done thing. *When I sit down Saturday morning, I'll finish the bookshelf.* C. Then you rest.

Balance isn't a place you reach and stay. It's more like walking: you tip, you correct, you tip again, and that's how you move forward. You'll lean again. Everyone does. Coming back needs no apology.

If a shadow has more hold on you than a lean, such as a compulsion you can't set down or a despair that won't lift, reach for someone you trust. The notebook can accompany care, but it can't replace it.

If the idea of a shadow doing a job for you resonates, Richard Schwartz's Internal Family Systems takes it much further. That work is best done with a trained therapist, ideally one who understands religious trauma.



WHAT FEELINGS POINT TO



FEELINGS often point past themselves. Anger points to a boundary, grief to love, envy to a desire. None of them are bad, and none of them are orders. They're messages, and carrying messages is Mercury's work.

When a feeling arrives and you want to understand it, find it below. Each comes with what it often points to, a question to ask, and the Wanderer it tends to speak for. Write the question on the page, and write whatever answer comes.

♂ **Pride** points to something you value in yourself. Ask it: *What did I do that felt truly mine?*

♂ **Shame** points to a longing to belong, often shaped by an old voice. Ask it: *Whose voice is this, and do I still believe it?*

♂ **Envy** points to a desire. Ask it: *What do they have that I want for my own life?*

♂ **Loneliness** points to a need for closeness. Ask it: *Who do I want near me, and what's one way to reach them?*

♂ **Weariness** points to a need for rest. Ask it: *What could I set down, even for an evening?*

♂ **Longing** points to something you miss, or haven't had yet. Ask it: *What part of that do I want in my life now?*

♂ **Anger** points to a boundary, or something that needs protecting. Ask it: *What was crossed, and what do I want to guard?*

♂ **Fear** points to something you care about. Ask it: *What am I protecting, and is the danger here now?*

♂ **Frustration** points to a goal that's blocked. Ask it: *What's in the way, and is it mine to move?*

♀ **Boredom** points to curiosity with nowhere to go. Ask it: *What would I rather be exploring?*

♀ **Confusion** points to a question worth asking. Ask it: *What exactly don't I understand yet?*

♀ **Anxiety** points to something you care about that isn't settled. Ask it: *What's one thing I can do, and what can I leave open?*

♀ **Restlessness** points to a road that's calling. Ask it: *Where do I want to go that I haven't let myself?*

2 **Hope** points to something you believe is possible. Ask it: *What small step would bring it closer?*

2 **Disappointment** points to a hope that didn't land. Ask it: *What was I hoping for, and do I still want it?*

2 **Resentment** points to giving that's out of balance. Ask it: *What have I been giving that I wish came back?*

2 **Awe** points to something larger than you. Ask it: *What did this show me about the size of things?*

♀ **Grief** points to love. Ask it: *What did I love, and how can I keep carrying it?*

♀ **Jealousy** points to something precious you're afraid to lose. Ask it: *What do I want to tend, and how?*

♀ **Delight** points to what you love. Ask it: *What exactly is sweet here, and how can I have more of it?*

♂ **Guilt** points to a value you hold. Ask it: *Did I cause harm, and is there something to mend?* If you didn't, ask instead: *Whose rule is this?*

♂ **Regret** points to what you'd choose now. Ask it: *What would I do differently, and where can I still do it?*

♂ **Overwhelm** points to too much at once. Ask it: *What's the one thing that matters most right now?*

♂ **Contentment** points to enough. Ask it: *What's here that I don't need to add to?*

Feelings point; they don't decide. Guilt can point to real harm, or only to a rule someone once handed you. Fear can point to real danger, or to a danger that's long past. The question is where your thinking starts, not where it ends.

Sometimes a feeling points to nothing at all. You're hungry, or tired, or it's only weather passing through. Not every feeling needs reading. Some only need to be felt, or fed, or slept on.

And if a feeling is too big to question, or it stays heavy for weeks, that's a low tide. Keep your visits small, and reach for someone you trust.

PAGES TO KEEP

A few pages earn a permanent place in the notebook. Keep them at the back, or wherever you'll find them.

Gifts from the Road. Record luck as it comes, both what found you and what you passed on: the unexpected check, the stranger's kindness, the book that appeared at the right time, the thing you gave away. On days when life feels scarce, read it. It's evidence that luck circulates.

The Savoring Page. Collect sumptuous moments and thank-yous, one line each. The first warm day. A meal that made you close your eyes. A friend's laugh. This is the page for low days, when you need proof that sweetness exists and has found you before.

The Map. Every season or so, look back over your Cs, kept and unkept, and write down what the pattern shows. What do you reliably follow through on? What keeps slipping? What does that say about what you value? Nothing here is graded. Values change, and when they do, you redraw the map.

Last Page, First Page. When a notebook fills, don't just close it. Reread it, skimming if you need to. On the last page, write it a goodbye letter, and note the open questions and carries you're bringing forward. Then open the new notebook, say hello, introduce yourself, and copy those questions and carries onto its first page. The Genius comes with you.

WHEN YOU NEED SOMETHING TO WRITE ABOUT

Some days the page stays blank. Here are some things worth writing about when you need one.

Low Tide. On waning days, when everything feels heavy, the visit can be very small: hello, one honest line, goodbye. That still counts. It may be the visit that counts most. You don't need a C on a day like that; a visit that carries nothing out is still complete. And if even one line is too much, open the notebook, say hello, and close it again. That counts too. If the low tide goes on and on, tell someone you trust. Letting yourself be nurtured is one of the teachings too.

Crossings. Life's thresholds deserve a page: birthdays, moves, new jobs, endings, first times, coming out, saying goodbye. Write on the eve of the crossing, about what you're leaving and what you hope for. Then write again once you're through.

Leave-Taking. Someone or something that's gone: a person, a place, a friendship, a self you used to be. Write them a goodbye, the way you'd close the notebook at the end of a visit. Tell them what they gave you and what you're keeping. You don't have to reach peace on the page. Some goodbyes take many visits, and if the loss is new and heavy, Low Tide applies: one line is enough.

Letters Forward. Write a letter to a future you, and mark the date you'll reread it: a month, a year, five years. Then turn the page and write back as that future you, answering what you just asked from the other side. When the day comes, reread both letters and answer them again, this time as the person you've actually become. It's the practice at its purest: one life speaking to itself across time.

Letters Back. Write to a younger you. Tell them what you know now that you wish they'd known then.

An Old Belief. Something you were taught to believe. Does it still hold up? What part of the map needs redrawing?

A Reclaimed Gift. Something you were taught to fear, like pleasure, anger, doubt, or desire. How are you making room for it now?

Where You're Leaning. Which Wanderer has been too loud lately, and which too quiet? If one stands out, walk it through Finding the Way Back.

The Hard Thing. A conversation you've been avoiding. Draft how you'd say it truthfully and kindly.

What Your Anger Is Saying. Name something that angered you. What is it protecting?

Someone Who Helped You Along. Someone who got you a little further down your road. What did they give you? Could you tell them?

Someone You Could Help. Whose road could you make a little easier right now?

A Sweet Thing, Slowly. Describe one pleasure in full detail, as if you were tasting it again.

Someone You Don't Understand Yet. A person you're struggling not to judge. Try to write the world from inside their eyes.

Something You'll Never Know. A question you'll never answer, and why you love it anyway.



Enough. What would be enough right now? What do you already have?

What You're Letting End. Something you're finishing, outgrowing, or letting go. What did it give you?

A Big Want. Something bigger than you've been allowed to want. Write it down as if it's possible, then walk it through Wanting Well.

Your Best Possible Self. Imagine your life a few years from now, having gone about as well as it realistically could. Write about it in detail: where you are, who's with you, what an ordinary day feels like. Then notice what it tells you about what you actually want. If something in it calls to you, walk it through Wanting Well.

The Stranger on the Road. A chance encounter that stuck with you, and why.

An Ordinary Good Day. Describe an unremarkable day that was quietly good, so you'll remember it.

What It Meant. If this were your last crossing, what would you want your life to have meant? Save this one for when you feel steady, not low.

HOW IT TIES TOGETHER



All seven Wanderers are at work in the practice:

- **Hello and goodbye** are Mercury's courtesy at the threshold.
- **Emptying your head** is the Moon: breathe out before you speak.
- **Writing as yourself, honestly**, is the Sun: letting yourself be seen, even if only by the page.
- **Rereading and responding** is Mercury again, the go-between, carrying messages between your past and present selves.
- **Q** is the Moon's wonder, letting questions stay open.
- **Wanting big**, and **passing luck along** in Gifts from the Road, are Jupiter.
- **C** is Saturn's heavy word, and **asking each visit whether you kept it** is Saturn's honesty.
- **Walking out of the notebook** and doing what you carried is Mars.
- **Savoring and gratitude** are Venus.
- **The Wanderers' lines** give each of the seven a small mark of its own on the page.
- **Coming back without apology** is Mercury, who always returns.
- **The whole practice** is the One Soul in miniature: one life speaking to itself across time.



ONE RULE FOR EVERYTHING ELSE

Before adding anything to this practice, ask: *Does it help me open the notebook and write?*

If it does, keep it. If it doesn't, let it go. No map is the territory, including this one.

ARE YOU GLAD?

Every so often, set the notebook down and ask the only question that really matters: *Am I glad I do this?*



Is your life a little more sumptuous? Are you kinder, braver, more curious? Do you feel more at home in yourself? Do the people around you feel more at home with you? Has the notebook become a sanctuary you carry?

If the answer is yes, keep going. If it's no, change what isn't working, or set the whole thing down. Nothing will follow you out the door. This practice was made for you, not you for it.

That's the reason it exists at all. Some of us lost a home when religion hurt us, and we still wanted meaning, rhythm, wonder, and a god at the crossroads, without the fear. This is one way to have those things: a way of living that asks nothing of you, and offers a life that feels like a place worth coming home to.

If it helps, use it. If it stops helping, let it go. And if you ever wander back, you already know what to say.

Hello.



PART FOUR

Adding Magick



*Everything in this part is optional. The practice is complete without it.
These are tools for anyone who wants to work magick through the notebook,
and they follow the same rules as everything else: no worship, no
supplication, no demands. Courtesy, curiosity, and honesty are enough.*



OLD NAMES, WITHOUT THE OLD DEBTS



YOU may be wondering why a book about setting down inherited religion now hands you an angel and an Enochian spirit. It's a fair question.

A name can be borrowed without the debts that came with it. Mercury comes from Greek and Roman religion, and nothing here asks you to take up that religion to walk with him. Raziel and AONT are the same. Raziel comes from Jewish mystical tradition, and AONT from the Enochian work of John Dee and Edward Kelley, two traditions with a long history of talking with what can't be seen. You can borrow what they learned without taking on their rules, their hierarchies, or their fear.

Nothing here is owed to either of them, any more than it's owed to Mercury. You don't call on them because a tradition says you must. You call on them because each is good at a particular job: Raziel at keeping secrets and translating, AONT at the clear insight that comes when the mind goes quiet. If that job ever stops being useful to you, set them down. They won't follow you out the door.

And if you'd rather meet them as parts of your own deep mind than as beings outside it, that works too. The Wanderers were offered the same way, and this book still doesn't ask you to decide.

RAZIEL, KEEPER OF SECRETS AND TRANSLATOR



AZIEL is an angel from Jewish mystical tradition whose name means something like "secret of God." A medieval book of magic, the *Sefer Raziel HaMalakh*, carries his name. In one old legend, after Adam left Eden, Raziel gave him a book of wisdom, not as punishment or instruction, but as comfort.

In this practice, Raziel does two things. He keeps secrets: the notebook is full of things you've never told anyone, and he's a fitting guardian for them. And he translates, between you and what you can't yet put into words, and between you and beings who don't speak a human language. Mercury carries messages; Raziel makes them legible. When you ask a Wanderer for help in Part Three, the answer usually arrives as something you notice, and Mercury's carrying is enough. When you want an answer you can write down, ask through Raziel.

You don't worship Raziel. You ask him for help the way you'd ask a well-read friend to help you with a difficult text.

AONT, THE SPIRIT OF AIR



AONT is the elemental being of the Spirit of Air, one of the names drawn from the Tablet of Union in the Enochian system of John Dee and Edward Kelley. Air is breath, speech, and thought. AONT sits at the center, the still point the others turn around, and its color is a pale, bright gold.

AONT's insight tends to arrive in something closer to the language of the gods than to plain English. That's why you ask through Raziel.

THE WEIGHT OF THE WORD



THIS is the foundation beneath every working here, so it's worth saying plainly. A word spoken with intent is a decree, and the world carries it in proportion to its weight. A word gets its weight from having been kept.

Every C you keep, however small, tells your deep mind and the world alike that what you say is real. Every one you let slide quietly teaches them that it isn't. So a working is not a wish said in the present tense. It's the next promise of someone with a record, spoken in the same voice that once wrote *When I sit down after lunch, I'll send the email*, and then sent it.

Chaos magick reaches for belief through intense focus. This practice builds it the slow way, one kept promise at a time, until a declaration is something you can stand behind without your mind arguing. That's why every working here ends with a step you actually take.

Everything that follows gives a weighted word a way to move. Emotional Transmutation gives it fuel. Declarative Alignment gives it a voice. A sigil gives it a shape your deep mind can carry past your conscious one. And the bridge, that step you take at the end, gives it legs.

Why would the world answer at all? No one can say for certain. But if the One Soul is the shape of things, a working isn't you commanding a world outside yourself. It's one voice of the whole speaking into the whole, and sometimes the whole answers. Reality is responsive, but not obedient.

ASKING AONT THROUGH RAZIEL

1. **Begin a visit as usual.** Say hello and empty your head.
2. **Write your question plainly,** and mark it with a Q.
3. **Lift it.** Breathing in, let the question rise from you into the open air. Ask Raziel, in your own words, to carry it to AONT and translate the answer into something you can understand.
4. **Receive.** Breathe out, then write whatever comes, without judging or editing it. If nothing comes, that's fine; answers often arrive later, as a flash, in their own time. Mark what you receive so you can find it again.
5. **Thank them both,** and say goodbye. Later, test what you received.

CALLING A WANDERER THROUGH RAZIEL

1. **Begin a visit as usual.** Say hello and empty your head. If you like, light the Wanderer's candle.
2. **Write your question plainly,** and mark it with a Q.
3. **Call it.** Read the Wanderer's list from Part Two slowly, as a way of calling it to mind, then call it by name.
4. **Ask.** Ask Raziel, in your own words, to carry your question to the Wanderer and translate what comes back. Then ask the Wanderer directly.

5. **Receive.** Breathe out, and write whatever comes, whether it feels like your own thought or not. Don't judge or edit it as it arrives. If nothing comes, that's fine; answers often arrive later, in their own time. Mark what you receive so you can find it again.
6. **Thank them both,** and say goodbye. Later, test what you received.

TESTING WHAT YOU RECEIVE



DON'T act on anything you receive right away. Leave it on the page, and come back to it days or weeks later. Reread it, and ask:

- Does it still hold true?
- Has it proven useful?
- Is it consistent with a way of living that's kind, honest, and harmless?

If it holds up, keep it. If it doesn't, let it go without embarrassment. Received material is a map like any other, and no map is the territory.

Discard anything that asks you to harm yourself or others, to cut yourself off from the people who love you, or to stop trusting your own judgment. And if received messages ever start to feel urgent, grandiose, or frightening, set this part of the practice down for a while and talk to someone you trust. Real insight is patient. It will still be there when you come back.

EMOTIONAL TRANSMUTATION

The working for what you actually want.



EMOTION is fuel. A heavy feeling can't be un-felt, but it can be tugged in a new direction, and its excess can be spent on something you want. Cast it in the middle of a visit, after you've emptied your head and reread, so that what you truly want has had room to surface. Not every feeling needs to be spent. Some only need to be felt.

1. **Empty it.** Sit with what you feel, name it, and write it out without dressing it up. Naming isn't a warm-up; it's half the work, because you can't transmute a feeling you can't get hold of. If it's overwhelming, try naming it in the third person first. If the page goes around the same loop three times, stop and move on.
2. **Weigh it.** From what you wrote, find what you actually want. Feelings often point past themselves: anger to a boundary, grief to love, envy to a desire, anxiety to something you care about. (What Feelings Point To, in Part Three, has many more.) Is what you want true? Will you still want it when it arrives? If the feeling is about another person, the intention is about your road, not theirs. Before a large working, ask AONT through Raziel.
3. **Declare it.** One sentence, in the present tense, describing the reality you want. Name the destination and leave the road.
4. **Feel the weight.** Hold the wanting and the heavy feeling together until you can sense them in your body.
5. **Remember the future.** Recall the moment it came true as a memory, not a hope: where you are, who's with you, what you can hear. Feel the relief, the joy, the gratitude. Write those feelings down, and stay with them until they have weight too.



6. **Push.** Call back the heavy sensation and press its weight into the relief and joy, until you've pushed enough. You'll know when to stop.
7. **Name the obstacle.** Still inside that memory, look back along the road. Write the main obstacle in you, and an if-then for when you meet it: *When [the obstacle] shows up, I will [action]*. For a large working, add one more question: imagine it's a year from now and the thing failed. Why?
8. **Send it.** Breathe in, then say your declaration, aloud or within, followed by:

*Mercury, open the way.
Raziel, carry this word.
AONT, breathe it into the world.
So it is written, so mote it be.*

On each exhale, see your breath as a bright, pale-gold mist, AONT's color, filling the space and settling down into the page. You breathe out, and the world breathes with you. The word is sent.

9. **Walk the bridge.** Write your thanks and your first step. Mark the step with a C, then do it. This isn't an afterthought. It's the half of the working that crosses from the page into the world, and the road only opens for the one who walks it.
10. **Let it go.** When the working comes to mind, thank it and turn away. Reread it when the practice brings you there, and note what has arrived. In between, leave it alone. A watched working is the conscious mind interfering.

One well-cast working is enough; don't pile others on top of it. Saying the same one again to renew it is fine, and so is casting it again if it hasn't landed. If you like, seal it with Declarative Alignment or a sigil.

If what rises is more than you can hold, stop. Set down the pen, breathe, feel your feet on the floor, and reach for someone you trust. The notebook can accompany care; it can't replace it.

DECLARATIVE ALIGNMENT



This can seal a Transmutation, said right after you send it, or stand on its own.

1. **Write it.** Write a present-tense statement of what you intend, slowly, feeling each word as you write it.
2. **Find the light.** Sit or stand straight and close your eyes. See yourself in an endless void. High above you is an impossibly bright pinprick of light. Then notice a second, just as bright, far beneath you. Bring your attention to the thread of light that connects them, passing through your center.
3. **Speak it.** Say, *"I align with this new reality,"* then speak your declaration aloud. As you speak, watch the thread vibrate with your voice, sending waves of golden light out across the universe. Picture the echo coming back to you as your new life.
4. **Make it walkable.** If you're using it on its own, name what inside you stands in the way, and write an if-then for it, as in Wanting Well. Carry it out as a C. A declaration with no plan can feel so satisfying that it quietly replaces the work.

Phrase your statement as something you can wholeheartedly stand behind. A declaration your mind argues with weakens itself; one that names a value you truly hold grows stronger every

time it's said. The strongest are about the one who walks rather than the road. Not *I will keep this promise*, but *I am someone whose word is good*.

MAKING A SIGIL



sigil is an intention compressed into a single shape, so your deep mind can carry it where your conscious mind would get in the way.

1. **Write it.** Your intention, in one sentence, in the present tense.
2. **Weigh it.** Make sure it's something you'll still want when it arrives. If a strong feeling stands behind it, work it through Emotional Transmutation first. If you're sealing a Transmutation, that's already done.
3. **Strike it.** Cross out every repeated letter, so that only one of each letter remains.
4. **Draw it.** Start combining the shapes of the remaining letters into flowing patterns. Keep combining, revising, and condensing until you like what you've drawn, and until, in the drawing, you've lost track of the words and feelings behind it.
5. **Choose its fate.** Decide what becomes of it: keep it in the notebook, draw it on a slip you'll burn, or fold it and carry it with you.
6. **Speak it.** Speak the intention over the sigil, aloud or within, and then do what you chose.

Making the sigil is enough. You can charge it further with breath or energy work if you like. If you make one in the middle of a page, draw a line around it to seal it off, and keep writing below.

Someday, while rereading, you'll come across it again. That's a good moment to note what happened.

DON'T SPECIFY THE ROAD



THIS is the most common way a working is weakened, so it deserves its own section. Declare the end state, and leave the route alone. Don't require the money to come from that client, the answer from that person, or the opening in that month. Every condition like that is a door you've nailed shut in a house with many doors.

This isn't passivity, and it doesn't excuse you from acting. You still walk the bridge: one concrete step, written and taken. What you will do is yours to specify, and should be specific. How the world will meet you isn't. Mercury moves along the roads nobody mapped. Insisting on the route is asking the god of crossings to take the only path you already know.

If a particular road matters to you for its own sake, then it isn't the road. It's the thing you actually want, and it should be declared as the destination instead.

WHEN A WORKING DOESN'T LAND



OMETIMES it doesn't arrive. Say so plainly on the page, with the date, as carefully as you'd record an arrival. Then look at your own side: did you walk the bridge? If you did, you kept your word, whatever the world did.

This practice will never tell you that you didn't believe hard enough, that a limiting belief blocked it, that you weren't aligned, or that part of you didn't really want it. That reasoning can't be disproven, and it's cruel: it turns every disappointment into proof of a personal defect. It's the same machinery as sin in a friendlier coat. A working that didn't land is a working that didn't land.

Ask the ordinary questions instead. Did you want the thing you declared, or something you thought you should want? Did you walk the bridge, or only write it? Was the timing wrong? Has it actually arrived by a road you didn't recognize, because you were watching one door?

Then ask: do you still want it? If you do, cast it again and keep going. If you don't, release it. Write *This working is finished*, and let it go. Nothing here is owed to you, and nothing here is your fault for not being owed it.

ONE RULE FOR THE MAGICK TOO



HE magick serves the life, never the other way around. Before adding any working to your practice, ask: *Does it help me live the way I want to, and keep opening the notebook?* If it does, keep it. If it doesn't, set it down. Coming back to it later needs no apology.



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When you've lived all of them, you'll hatch.